



LIMBO

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In times when run-n-gun FPS games rule the roost, Limbo comes as a welcome change. This beautifully crafted Indie game offers one of the most interesting gaming experiences, excelling in game-play, visual and sound design. In fact, we'll go as far as to say that this is one of the best games to come out across any platform over the last 12 months - in fact the PC version launched just a month ago on August 2.

Let us start out by saying that Limbo is not for the faint of heart. Its 'trial and death' styled learning curve force you to see the game's boy protagonist being charred, maimed, decapitated, perforated and impaled to death in the most gruesome fashion imaginable. With no special tools at your disposal and a harsh and unforgiving environment that demands every second of your attention, Limbo gives you no quarter if you slack off.

PLOT

There's no narrative as such. You're a silhouetted boy with bright white eyes

who wakes up in the middle of a forest, searching for his missing sister. This forest is full of things, living and non-living, which are most eager to kill you. The controls are dead simple. You use the arrow keys to get around and the control key helps you grab in-game objects.

But don't let the simplicity fool you. This beautiful and eerie platformer-cum-physics puzzle has a lot to offer. It's monochromatic, film-noir environment gives it this unnerving feeling. The background always has something moving in it and even the little blades of grass sway when the boy walks past it.

The game relies heavily on ambient sounds to give the player cues which help solve the puzzle. Though music is present at times, it's used to accentuate emotional high-points in the game. In later levels, you must time your moves according to the ticking countdown timer. Failing to do so might get you killed. But, the game is very forgiving that way. Once you die, you're immediately taken back to the last checkpoint. So dying in Limbo really isn't that punishing from a game-play perspective - thankfully.

Then again, Limbo doesn't trivialise death. In fact, it shows you how fragile

this boy protagonist is. Make one wrong move and the boy pays for it. Even though the game's colour schematic is limited to just black and white, the boy's death has much more of an emotional impact on you than any ultra-realistic blood red flesh wound you'd see in triple A games. Just goes to show how simple games crafted with precision can trigger emotions as well or better than photo-realistic graphics.

An average Limbo playthrough will take between 5-6 hours. The puzzles aren't simple or tough-as-nails hard. The difficulty is just right and best of all, there aren't any loading screens! So once you're in Limbo, it's hard to leave it till the very end.

VERDICT

If video games were art, then Limbo would be in the Louvre. Limbo is fun, scary, exciting, well thought out and engrossing. Sure you'll get frustrated when you die repeatedly, but that's what makes Limbo great. Just like life, you have to learn about it the hard way. Download it off Steam right now. **d**

Genre: Puzzle, Platformer
Developer: Playdead
Publisher: Microsoft Game Studios, Playdead
Price: ₹450 approx (Steam download)

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